Q+A

BRIDGING THE GAP

Esther Duflo's ***Poor Economics for Kids*** **is an illustrated children's version of the seminal economics text she co-wrote with Abhijit V. Banerjee**

Q. Why did you decide to do this children's book?

I always wanted to do it. I thought it was interesting to highlight the subject for children, operating with a very different set of constraints and codes. People who live in poverty are kind of invisible and not really talked about for children. I thought it important to reach children with good literature on a topic they are not exposed to often.

Q. How challenging was it to simplify complex economic concepts?

I don't think I could have written this children's book without first writing *Poor Economics*. It requires you to understand a topic extraordinarily well to be able to concentrate it into these nuggets. The key is not what is complicated; the key is what's important to say.

Q. How did a busy economist like you find the time to do the book?

The project predated Covid but it was only during the lockdown that Cheyenne Olivier, the illustrator, who was living with us at the time, and I were able to sit down and actually do it. Other people started baking and we wrote a book! It eventually took us three years to wrap up the project.

Q. Is this the beginning of a parallel career as a children's book writer?

It's not the beginning, it's the end! Although the Indian version published by Juggernaut is one book, in the original French it was 10 separate books. I'm back to adults for my next one on climate justice.

—with Amit Dixit



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